The CareLeaders

Programme brochure

Designated* Leaders

* from designated teacher to designated leader

A year-long leadership programme for designated teachers, commissioned by virtual schools.

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Why we created it

Children in care and children with a social worker face some of the biggest barriers in education.

We designed the Designated Leaders Programme to help solve them, starting with the one person in every school whose job it already is.

Every maintained school and academy must have a designated teacher for children in care and previously in care. It is a statutory leadership role, yet it often comes with little training and little support. This programme is designed to close that gap.



That's why we created the Designated Leaders Programme.

The children it is for

1 in 30	children in England is a child in need. Roughly one in every classroom.
3 in 5	children in care have identified special educational needs, against 1 in 5 of all pupils.
1 in 5	children in care has moved school in the last two years.
0	mentions of trauma, attachment or children in care in the Initial Teacher Training and Early Career Framework.

Sources: Department for Education, Children in need 2025; Outcomes for children in need, including children looked after, 2024 to 25; Stability measures for children looked after in England, 2025; Initial Teacher Training and Early Career Framework, January 2024.

What it is

A year-long leadership programme for designated teachers. They learn practical tools chosen for their own schools, learn how to teach them, and lead training for their whole staff. All designed to support children in care, children with a social worker and those who have experienced adversity.

Six sessions
Three face-to-face days, three 90-minute online sessions

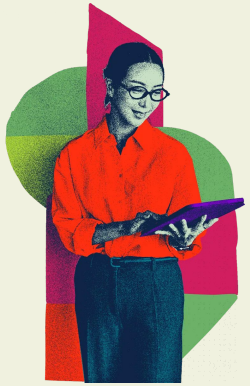
Nine tools
Chosen from 26, based on your schools' audits

Workbooks
A workbook, facilitation guide, slides and video for every tool

Online platform
The nine tools now, all 26 for a year after

A community
Designated teachers across your authority

Staff training
A full training day for their whole staff at September INSET



Who this programme is for

Role	The designated teacher for children in care and previously in care
Must be	A qualified teacher, or the head or acting head
Also suits	SENCOs, pastoral and inclusion leads, senior mental health leads and heads of year
Joins	A cohort of up to 60 across your authority

What they learn

From designated teacher to designated leader.

Our mission is to turn designated teachers into designated leaders. Across the year, each teacher builds their knowledge, learns the tools, then passes them on to colleagues.

Knowledge

Understanding the children in their school

The barriers that children in care, children with a social worker and those who have experienced adversity face in education.

How children develop, and the messages in their behaviour.

How to run a behaviour audit and a data audit, and use what they show.

Tools

Practical ways to support them

Nine tools chosen from the first audit, so the programme is built on their school's needs.

Each tool comes with a workbook, facilitation guide, slides and video.

Tools such as PACE, emotion coaching and the window of tolerance, ready to use with children.

Facilitation

Passing the tools on to others

How to plan training with each tool's facilitation guide.

How to design and rehearse a full training day for September INSET.

How to use the audits to show what has changed.

What they keep

- A workbook, facilitation guide, slides and video for every tool
- A full staff training day, ready for September INSET
- Their school's audit, from the start and the end of the year
- All 26 tools, for a year after the programme ends
- A network of designated teachers across the authority

How the programme works, in three steps.

Every local authority has its own challenges, so we don't sell an off-the-shelf course. We teach a library of 26 tools, and we build each programme from the ones your schools need most.

1

Designated teachers audit their school

In the first session, each designated teacher completes a behaviour audit and a data audit in their own school, using the previous year's data. It shows the behaviours in classrooms, what is already working, and where children need the most support.

→

2

We build the programme

We read every audit and find the themes your schools share. Then we choose nine tools from our library of 26, three for each term. You see the selection and why we chose it.

→

3

We teach the programme

Across six sessions, designated teachers learn each tool, use it with children and plan training for their staff. Every tool comes with a workbook, facilitation guide, slides and video.

Autumn: three tools **Spring: three tools** **Summer: three tools** **Grey: the other 17, yours after the programme**

26 **All 26 tools, once the programme is complete.** Every designated teacher then gets access to the full library, with every workbook and facilitation guide, for a further year.

Our library: 26 tools in five areas.

Your programme teaches nine of them, chosen from your schools' audits. Every tool comes with a workbook, facilitation guide, slides and video. When the programme is complete, designated teachers get all 26 for a further year.



Connect 7 tools

- PACE
- Emotion Coaching
- Spot, Soothe, Shift
- Key Adult
- Feelings Wheel
- Network Hand
- Comic Strip Conversations

Calm 4 tools

- Regulate, Relate, Reason
- Window of Tolerance
- Stress Bucket
- Strike While the Iron Is Cold

Repair 4 tools

- Separating Reason from Behaviour
- Restorative Questions
- Language that Cares
- Collaborative and Proactive Solutions

Understand 6 tools

- Poker Chip Theory
- Three Houses
- Post-Traumatic Growth
- Ecomap
- Tree of Life
- Life Story Conversations

Plan 5 tools

- Growth Mindset
- WOOP
- Scaling Questions
- PATH
- OARS

What they get

The year in numbers.

6 — **Six sessions**
Three face-to-face days, three 90-minute online sessions

9 — **Nine tools**
Chosen from 26, based on the first audit

9 — **Workbooks**
A workbook, facilitation guide, slides and video for every tool

26 — **The full library**
All 26 tools, for a year after the programme

60 — **A community**
Up to 60 designated teachers across your authority

1 — **Staff training**
A full training day for their whole staff at September INSET

The learner's journey

A school year, term by term.

Plan → **Do** → **Review** Every term, teachers plan in a session, try it in school, then review it together.

Autumn
Understand the children

1 — Online, 90 minutes
Introduction: Understanding Children

2 — Face to face, full day
Understanding and Responding to the Messages in Behaviour

In school
Complete the behaviour and data audits. They set the tools for every session.

Spring
Put the tools to work

3 — Online, 90 minutes
Reviewing the Tools

4 — Face to face, full day
What Your Teachers Need to Know

In school
Use the next three tools with children, and share what works.

Summer
Go deeper and prepare

5 — Online, 90 minutes
Going Deeper

6 — Face to face, full day
Preparing the INSET Day

In school
Plan the INSET training day with the facilitation guides, and agree it with senior leaders.

September
Lead the day

✳ **INSET day**

26 — For a year after
The full library

In school
Lead a full training day for the whole staff at INSET.

The audits, twice. At the start, each school's behaviour and data audits look at the previous year, and set the tools for every session. At the end of the programme we capture them again, to explore what has changed.

The online platform

Every session and every tool, on any screen.

From the first face-to-face day, each teacher has the nine tools and the content of every session, so anyone who misses one can catch up. When the programme ends, all 26 tools open up for a further year.

What the platform includes

Every session
Catch up on anything you miss.

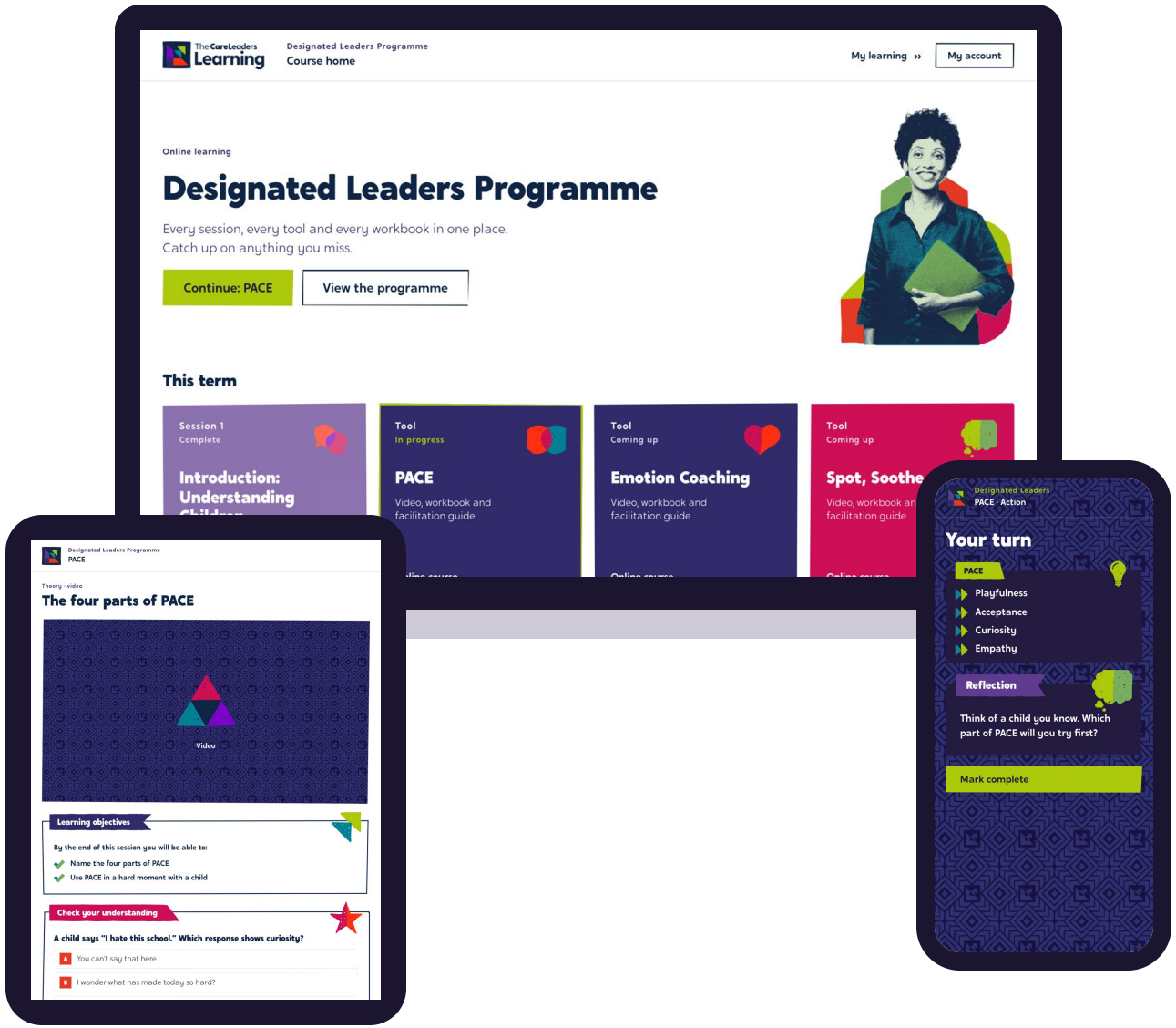
Your nine tools
An online course for each tool you are taught.

Story, theory, action
Short videos that walk through every tool.

Workbooks and slides
Download, print or teach from them.

Facilitation guides
Plan your INSET training day with them.

The full library
All 26 tools for a year after the programme.



What changes

By September, every school has its own trainer.

01 A profile of need for the children in each school who need the most support, built by the people who know them

02 Nine practical tools in use in classrooms across your authority

03 Training written and delivered in each school by one of its own

04 Training capacity built inside your schools, so you don't buy the same training in again next year

05 A cohort of designated teachers who know each other and share practice

Year 1

One year of learning with us

Onboarded onto the platform after the first face-to-face day. Six sessions, nine tools, and an INSET day of their own.

Year 2

One year of access to our resources

12 months' access to all 26 tools, workbooks and facilitation guides, until the end of the following summer term.

What you keep

Nothing we build stays ours.

- Every tool, slide deck, workbook and facilitation guide, co-designed with you and handed over
- 12 months' access to all 26 tools after the programme, until the end of the following summer term
- A marketing toolkit, co-branded with your logo, to promote the programme to your schools
- The tool selection, and why we chose it

Case study

DARLINGTON
Borough Council

Darlington Virtual School

April 2025 to July 2026. Co-design, programme design, resources and delivery.

30 designated teachers trained

10 months, one school year

3 face-to-face days, with online sessions between

The training designated teachers designed for themselves.

Designated teachers in Darlington told us most of their training ticked a box and changed nothing. They asked for practical tools, time with each other, and facilitators with lived and professional experience. So we designed the alternative with them. Designated Leaders started here.

Listen

On 10 April 2025, 30 designated teachers told us what makes training worth their time. They pitched the worst programme they could imagine, and we turned each pitch into a fix.

Design

We built the highest-scoring ideas into a programme that follows the school year, with a task to complete in school between sessions.

Build

Onboarding pack, workbooks, lesson plans, slide decks and games, plus access to our online platform.

Deliver

Face-to-face days in September 2025, January 2026 and April 2026, each followed by work in their own school.

What changed

The Virtual School widened the reach as the year went on. By the third face-to-face day, staff from a secondary school it had struggled to reach were in the room.

Also facilitating in Salford City Council wakefieldcouncil

In their words

Something that you can take back to the school and actually use.

A designated teacher, Darlington
Co-design workshop, April 2025, on what makes training worth their time





Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Your facilitator

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19 and has spent his career since inside children's services, as a consultant, trainer, board member and national engagement lead.

He designed the Designated Leaders Programme with designated teachers in Darlington, after they told us most of their training ticked a box and changed nothing. What they asked for was something they could take back to school and actually use.

He has worked alongside virtual schools across England. He led a national co-design process with Virtual School Heads through NAVSH, and helped Liverpool Virtual School produce its 2025 conference for headteachers, designated teachers and social workers, with young people designing and running their own workshop.

He founded The Care Leaders in 2017, and it has since worked with 36 local authorities and national bodies, including the Department for Education. He led the national engagement on the Department for Education's rewrite of the Fostering Services National Minimum Standards.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026
- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families
- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, 2020 to 2021
- **Social Entrepreneur Fellow**
  School for Social Entrepreneurs, 2015 to 2017

Designated * Leaders

Everything you need to fill every place.

Before the first session, we give your virtual school a marketing toolkit to tell every school about the programme. You hold the list and invite schools. We help you get designated teachers signed up, released and through the door.

How we help people sign up and attend

- We fill in your dates, venues and contacts from one short questionnaire.
- Everything is co-branded with your logo, and editable in Word and Canva.
- An email for headteachers asks them to release their designated teacher for the three face-to-face days.
- A reminder goes out before the sign-up deadline, so no school misses its place.
- Online sessions run after school, 3:30 to 5pm, so teachers are not taken out of class.

Your marketing toolkit



Poster
A4, for staffrooms



Flyer
To send with every email



Three emails
Designated teachers, headteachers and a reminder



Programme brochure
Co-branded, for headteachers and designated teachers



Newsletter item
For your schools bulletin



QR code
Straight to sign-up

The CareLeaders

Getting started

Four steps to your first cohort.

1 Get in touch

Email us, or scan the QR code and fill in our short form about your schools.

2 Have an initial call

We reply within 3 working days to book a call about your schools, your cohort and your dates.

3 We provide a quote

A clear price for your whole cohort, and what is included.

4 We facilitate your training

We build your programme from your schools' audits and run it across the year.

hello@thecareleaders.com

Scan to tell us about your schools

A five-minute form that gives us what we need for our first call.

What we need from you

- A venue for the three face-to-face days
- The list of designated teachers. Your virtual school holds the list and invites schools directly; we don't take bookings from schools
- Help promoting the programme to your schools, using the co-branded marketing toolkit we provide
- A named contact in the virtual school to agree the tool selection and dates

Commissioned by your virtual school for the whole cohort, so schools pay nothing to take part. Contact us for a price.

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

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